

RACHIT GOSWAMI

Drone Dynamo

ANKIT MEHTA, 32

Co-founder and CEO, IdeaForge Mumbai

When Pakistani terrorists struck Mumbai in November 2008, Ankit Mehta, then a student at IIT Bombay, saw Indian security forces struggle to locate the gunmen in the maze of hotels. It convinced him the technology he was developing for remotely operated vehicles was the solution. That was the take-off point for one of India's pioneering drone start-ups. Mehta's aerial vehicle made its debut in the 2009 Bollywood film *Three Idiots* and now, over a decade later, IdeaForge is India's largest drone-maker and his firm has over 20 patents.

An IdeaForge drone takes off once in six minutes across the country running a range of tasks from classified military surveillance missions to mapping agricultural land and surveying infrastructure projects. The drones have a range of between two and 15 kilometres and can fly a maximum of 6,000 metres. His customers have done over 200,000 missions using his platforms. Business boomed during the twin crisis last year—the pandemic—and China's aggressive border deployment in eastern Ladakh. His drones were used for law enforcement and lockdown management. And in January 2021, the Indian Army placed an order worth over Rs 140 crore for IdeaForge's 'Switch' drones that can operate at high altitudes. "Give me a mission and I'll give you the product," Mehta says. ■

–Sandeep Unnithan

LOW TECH MUST-HAVE
Dangles at least three carabiners around his waist to make sure he doesn't lose things

"We build the technology that impacts national security and food security"